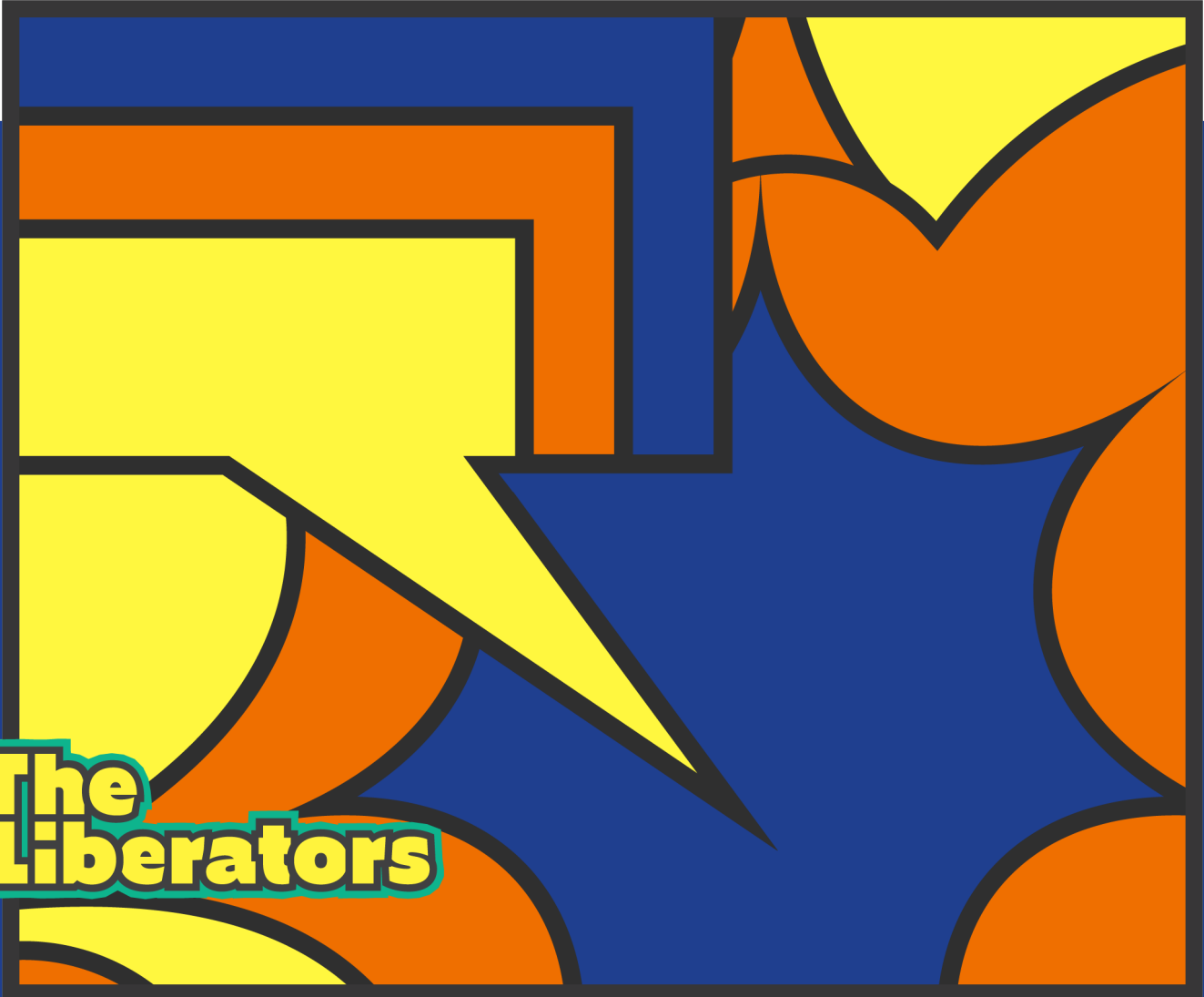


Improve How Your Scrum Team Uses Sprint Goals

With this Retrospective format, your Scrum team learns why a Sprint Goal matters, and how to address the root cause for not using it



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Shared goals are very important in Scrum. But although almost everyone agrees with that, few teams actually do it. Why is that?

For Scrum teams that don't have a Sprint Goal, each Sprint feels the same: just finish all the items on the Sprint Backlog. They struggle to make decisions about what's important, and everyone tries to look busy and finish as much work as possible. Scrum events become meaningless, and because there's no focus on delivering value, the Sprint Review, in particular, becomes obsolete. Why should you invite your stakeholders if you have no idea a Sprint was successful?

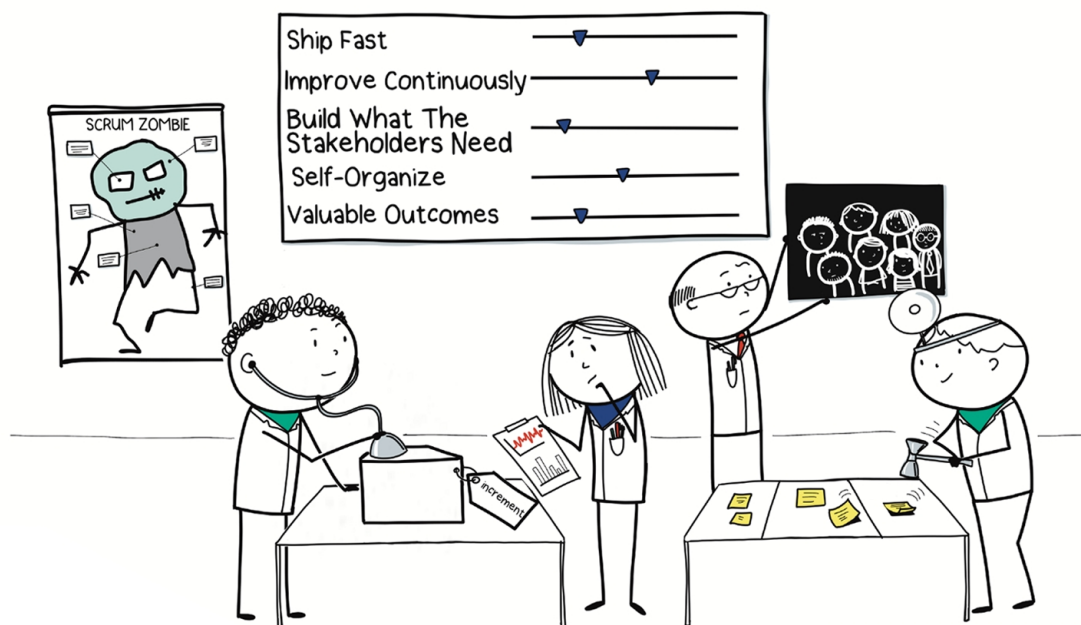
A Scrum team that doesn't use a Sprint Goal will experience something else as well: they don't work as a team. It's only a bunch of individuals sharing the same (virtual) space, but there's no coherence, no collaboration around a shared purpose, and no sense of direction.

To make the importance of the Sprint Goal clear, it's easy to dictate the Scrum Guide. The term "goal" is one of the most emphasized concepts. Yet we believe it's more powerful to let your team discover this by themselves. That's the intention of this do-it-yourself workshop, which contains the Liberating Structures TRIZ, Discovery & Action Dialogue, and 15% Solutions.

Give this string a try, and let us know the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Channel Your Very Worst With TRIZ

  35 min

Step 3: Discover Local Solution To Chronic Problems With "Discovery & Action Dialogue"

  60 min

Step 4: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

  20 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 120 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



If TRIZ results in a problem everyone can relate to, the questions from Discovery & Action Dialogue will help the team figure out potential solutions by themselves.

Impact On Survival



This experiment helps your Scrum team solve the right problems and builds the skill set to more effectively analyze those problems.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. You can also run parallel sessions of this string at the same time, involving many more Scrum teams and many more stakeholders.

Intended Audience

This workshop is designed for one Scrum team, which includes the Product Owner, Scrum Master, and the Developers.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where you can collect insights from the various rounds.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.



Why Shared Goals Matter



The Scrum framework is adamant about shared goals – like the Sprint Goal and the Product Goal. They encourage coherence and collaboration. Without shared goals, it might be tempting for people to just put their blinders on and work as hard as they can on individual tasks. But that way, you can't benefit from the advantages of teamwork. And that is a huge waste.

Organizational and cognitive psychologists have long understood that clear, shared goals are an enabler for high-performing teams in complex environments. Shared goals increase cohesion in a group, make work more motivating and reduce the need for ongoing communication in meetings, on Slack, or by e-mail. That makes sense, right? If there is one clear goal for a Sprint, it is easier to decide what is more important. Are you going to spend a lot of time refactoring some code that works, but can be better? Or are you going to fix that critical bug that prevents your team from achieving the Sprint Goal? If you have one clear long-term Product Goal, this guides what work should end up on the Product Backlog and what may be a great idea, "but not right now". So shared goals reduce waste on the one hand while making your work together more motivating on the other.

Another benefit of shared goals is that they help your team and its environment to understand what is valuable about the work and why it matters (or not). Without goals, work tends to turn into an assembly line where people do what they are told without knowing the big picture. And because they don't, people can't contribute with their ideas. Instead, they likely get lost in excessive gold-plating, repetitive work, or low motivation.

So why have so many teams and organizations not yet realized that shared goals are not a nice-to-have, but a critical characteristic of high-performing teams? Unfortunately, work in many organizations is not optimized for shared goals, but to accommodate functional specialization (designers design, coders code, analysts analyze), office politics (the people screaming the loudest get their items in the Sprint), because stakeholders are never involved at all (no sense of what is valuable) or an entirely ad-hoc approach (no vision, no goals).

This string is designed to help you find starting points where you can increase collaboration through shared goals. Whatever you do, a goal that isn't 100% clear is still better than no goal at all. So don't start at the end, but begin where you are and continuously improve your way towards a great shared goal. This string should help!



About The Sprint Retrospective

If you give this do-it-yourself workshop a try during the Sprint Retrospective, it's useful to have a good understanding of the purpose of this Scrum event.

The Sprint Retrospective happens at the end of the Sprint, usually right after the Sprint Review. It is attended by the entire Scrum team. Its purpose is to inspect how the Scrum team worked together to achieve the Sprint Goal, and identify concrete steps that can be taken in the next Sprint to increase effectiveness and quality. Where the Sprint Review is more focused on the product and the content of the work that was done, the Sprint Retrospective is aimed at inspecting the process of how that work was done.

For Sprints of a month, the Sprint Retrospective should take no more than three hours. But the shorter the Sprint, the shorter the timebox tends to be. Based on what the Scrum team has learned from the inspection of their collaboration, they may decide to make adjustments to work more effectively. This can involve an updated Definition of Done, researching new tools or technologies, a change in working agreements, or a different team composition.

Read a more detailed description [here](#) if you'd like to learn more.



Created by Thies Rühmann for the ZenHub Scrum Survival Guide
by Christian Vennep, Johannes Schabus & Barry Ooms



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast! We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Channel Your Very Worst With TRIZ

The Liberating Structure TRIZ is a great way to flip the script. Instead of dreaming up ideal futures, it asks your teams to identify all that is in their power to make things as bad as possible. It immediately creates painful transparency about the counterproductive activities and behaviors the Scrum team must stop. It does so in a cathartic way that is entertaining, engages, and involves everyone, and is bound to create some laughs along the way.

In this structure, the invitation asks your team to shift into the worst possible team they can imagine themselves to be. It is often surprisingly easy to figure out how to fail, so expect deliciously evil ideas, laughter, and hilarity. The second round of TRIZ turns everything around and can be a painful eyeopener. It also sets the foundation to stop counterproductive activities, immediately.

Invitation

"What can we do as a Scrum team to guarantee that our work lacks as much coherence as possible? That we're all working on our own islands, without any overlap and collaboration? And without any shared sense of direction?"

Steps

- **3 min** First individually and in silence, ask everyone to compile a list of all the things they can do, individually or as a team, to guarantee the worst outcome.
- **5 min** Invite people into pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Ask everyone to share their lists and expand them together. Encourage people to go wild with this one; more is better!
- **3 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, invite everyone to go over the items they wrote on their lists. Ask: "In silence, go through your list and mark the items that resemble or might eventually result from something you're already noticing in this team".
- **10 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Ask the people to share what they recognized in their pairs.
- **3 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, invite everyone to decide what they're going to stop doing from now on. Ask: "Based on the items that we recognized in our own team, what seems important about moving forward as a team? What is something we should absolutely stop doing?"
- **10 min** Invite people into new pairs and move them into separate breakouts. Here, people can share what they are going to stop doing from now on.
- **5 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, you can ask if anyone has anything they feel comfortable sharing with the whole group. What patterns did people notice?

Our Findings



- Invite participants to have fun, go a bit over the top and have a laugh while they're doing it. This helps create a safe environment where people feel comfortable being honest;
- Don't spoil the twist in TRIZ between the first and second rounds. Doing so will limit creativity and the brutal honesty that makes TRIZ work, as people will already start reflecting on their current situation during the first round;
- We purposefully picked pairs instead of small groups. This creates more safety than small groups when it comes to the kinds of personal stories that this application of TRIZ may result in. If you feel there is ample safety in the group, you can also work with groups of four.

Resources

- Blogpost: [Stop counterproductive activities and behaviors to make space for innovation with TRIZ](#)
- The [original article on TRIZ](#) on the Liberating Structures website



So, what happens without a Sprint Goal?

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- The collage illustrates the 'Without Sprint Goals' workshop. The top left photo shows a group of people in a workshop setting, some sitting at tables and others standing. The top right photo shows a person in a yellow shirt and another in a striped shirt on the floor, surrounded by many small, colorful sticky notes. The middle left photo shows a group of people standing around a table, looking at a large sheet of paper with many sticky notes. The middle right photo is a diagram titled 'WITHOUT SPRINT GOALS' showing a central figure with arrows pointing to six red boxes: 'NO CLEAR FOCUS', 'ALL PRINCE', 'ALL PRINCE', 'NO FOCUS ON THE GOAL', 'NO FOCUS ON THE GOAL', and 'NO FOCUS ON THE GOAL'. The bottom photo shows a group of people sitting at tables, looking at a large sheet of paper with many sticky notes.

Examples Of Real Sprint Goals

Although most Scrum teams see the value of Sprint Goals, how to create them is a huge source of confusion and frustration. Is the Sprint Goal there before the Sprint Backlog? How do you create a Sprint Goal out of the unrelated set of items at the top of your Product Backlog? And should everything on the Sprint Backlog be related to the Sprint Goal?

There are many great articles available that present a conceptual model for thinking about Sprint Goals. But no matter the model, people frequently struggle to translate it to their own work.

So instead, we decided to write the story of a real product and (some of) the Sprint Goals we used there. By working from real examples, we hope we can help people build a better understanding of the kind of reasoning that informs Sprint Goals. And how it shapes both the Sprint Backlog, refinement and the other way around.

For more details, check the article [Examples Of Real Sprint Goals](#).





Step 3: Discover Local Solution To Chronic Problems With "Discovery & Action Dialogue"

In the previous step, you used TRIZ to identify what may be impeding your team in developing shared goals. In our experience, the outcome usually results in what we describe as a "lack of cohesion". You may notice that people put their blinders on, and work only on their own tasks. Or the Sprint Backlog may be a lackluster assortment of items without any coherence.

To explore this lack of cohesion more deeply, the Liberating Structure Discovery & Action Dialogue is a great choice. Rather than giving up or immediately reaching to "best practices" that worked elsewhere, it helps groups carefully analyze the problem, potential solutions, and how everyone can contribute to both. It also builds helpful problem-solving skills in groups by providing them a useful structure to think about challenges in general.

The questions of Discovery & Action Dialogue

As the name suggests, this structure takes the shape of structured dialogue. Small groups answer the following questions. Whenever we talk about "the problem", you can also replace it with something more specific to your team – like "a lack of coherence in our work" or "unclear shared goals":

- How do you know when the problem is present?
- How do you contribute effectively to solving the problem?
- What prevents you from doing this or taking these actions all the time?
- Do you know anybody who is able to frequently solve this problem and overcome barriers? What behaviors or practices made their success possible?
- Do you have any ideas?
- What needs to be done to make it happen? Any volunteers?
- Who else needs to be involved?

Although there is a purposeful order to the questions, you can deviate from it if it makes more sense to you.

Steps

- Create a shared space (on a wall, the floor, or virtually) where you can collect insights and answers from the various rounds.
- **5 min** Briefly introduce the problem the Scrum team will focus on, and how it connects to the outcome of TRIZ. Divide the team into small groups with 3 – 5 participants and prepare the breakout rooms. Make sure everyone has a worksheet with the questions.
- **2 min** Each group picks a "Guide" and a "Butterfly Catcher". The Guide asks the questions while the Butterfly Catcher captures insights and quotes. Both the Guide and the Butterfly Catcher also answer the questions themselves, so they have an extra responsibility. The groups also decide on a talking object. Only the person holding it can speak and decide who goes next.
- **35 min** In their breakout rooms, the small groups answer the questions offered by the Guide. Make sure to always start with 1-minute of individual thinking and reflection. Only when the question is sufficiently addressed, the group moves on to the next question.
- **5 min** When all the questions are covered, the Butterfly Catcher recaps the outcomes, identified the next steps, and people that need to be included.
- **10 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask the Butterfly Catchers to summarize the findings of each group.

Our Findings

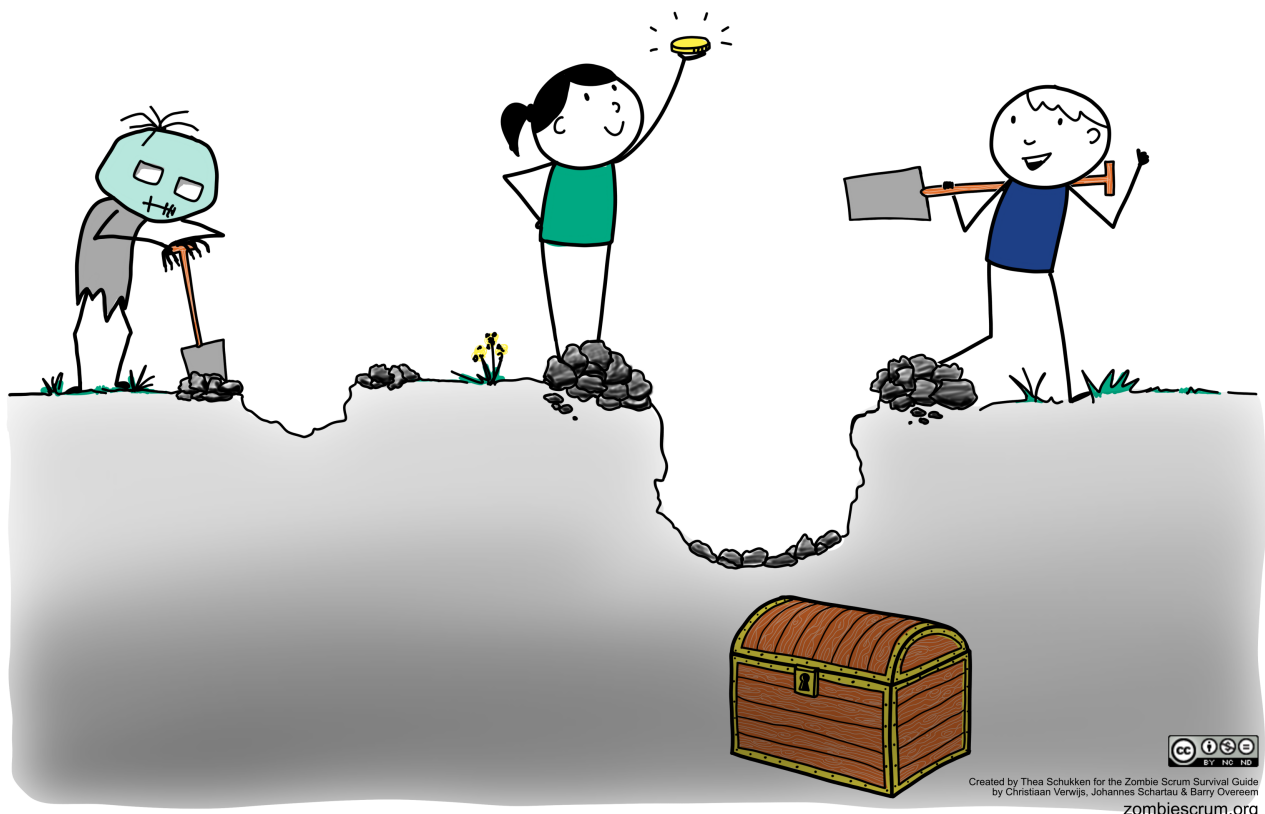
- When you run this structure with multiple teams, add opportunities for teams to share their findings with the

whole group and gather feedback. A Liberating Structure such as [Shift & Share] is ideal for this.

- Encourage the team to spend enough time on the first question. Ask additional questions such as "What's so challenging about this problem?", "Is there a deeper problem we're not seeing?", or "What happens when we don't solve this problem?" will help you dig deeper.

Resources

- The original article on [Discovery & Action Dialogue](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Discover and Unleash Local Solutions to Chronic Problems with [Discovery & Action Dialogue](#)



Step 4: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

In the previous step, you used Discovery & Action Dialogue to find a solution for the lack of cohesion within the Scrum team. In this closing exercise, the Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) is used to have each team member determine their personal next steps.

Invitation

"What is a personal 15% Solution that you can take personally to help make you and this team more successful? What is something you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"

Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partners find ways to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

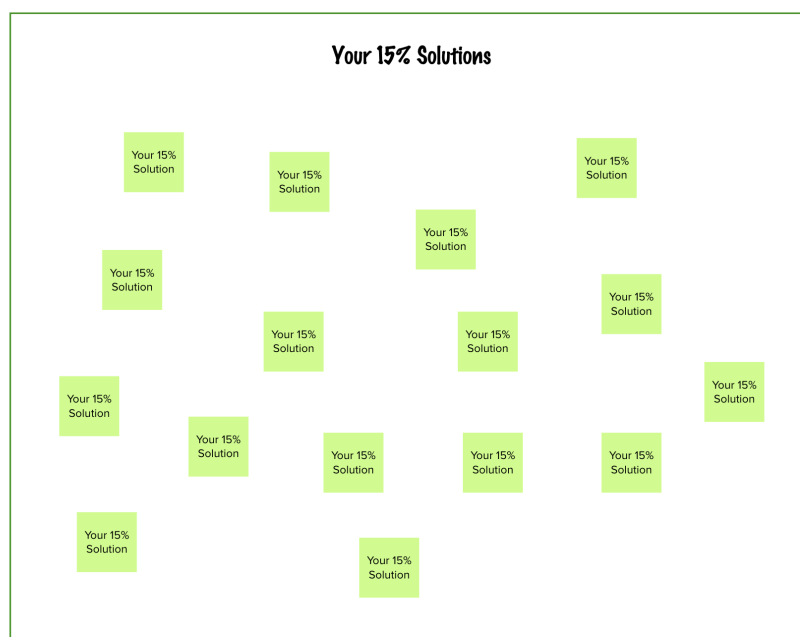
Step 1

Position yourself in the scenario you recognize the most and write down a personal next step.

What is an improvement that you can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources you don't have access to?

Step 2

Pair up and share your 15% Solution while giving and getting help to refine your next step



Step 5: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this gathering?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

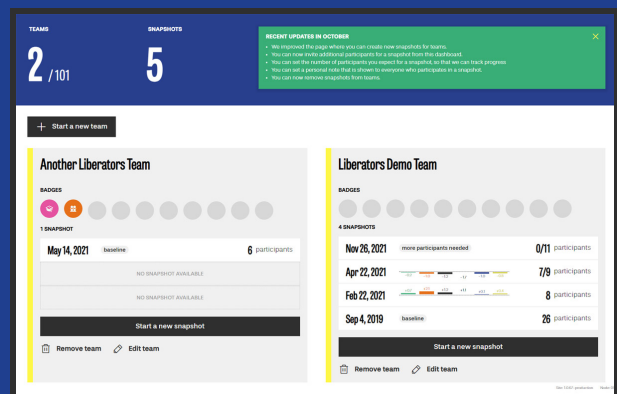
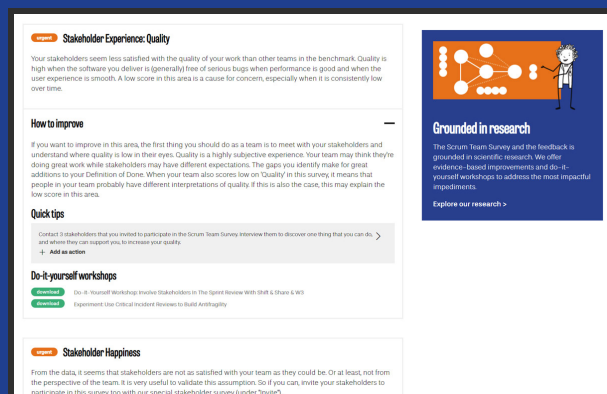
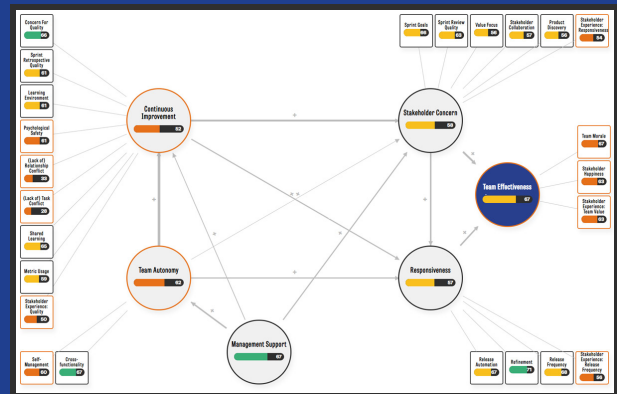
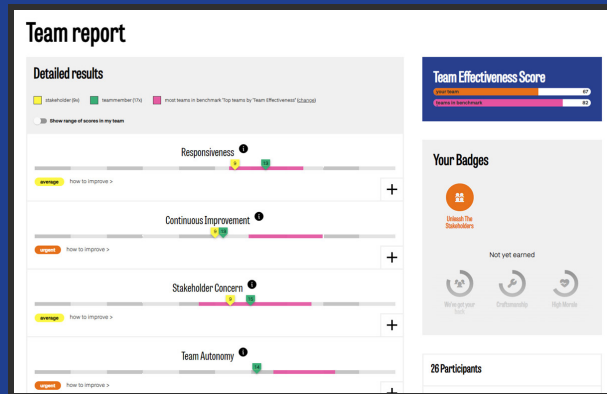
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
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See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
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<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

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